Can We See John Stockton's Heart Rate in the Box Score?

3-Post NBA Durability Series — Status 2026-10-13 (v4)

The Premise

John Stockton and Boris Diaw reportedly share a resting heart rate of ~35 BPM — well below the elite-athlete norm of ~50 BPM. The question: does that physiology leave a detectable trace in box-score data as statistical resilience — fewer missed games, steadier late-game performance, more durable decision-making under fatigue? Stockton's durability is currently circulating on social media, providing a natural hook.

Post Structure

Post	Subject	Data Window
1	John Stockton + 14 PG comps	E1/E3 full career 1984–2003; E2/E4/E5 1996–2003 only
2	Boris Diaw + 5 PF comps (Nowitzki, Boozer, Jamison, Marion, Lewis)	2004–2016, full BRef
3	All qualifying BRef-era guards + forwards + centers	1980–2010 debuts

Stockton ships first to ride the current conversation; Diaw follows immediately as independent methodological confirmation — different position, different era, full BRef coverage, no age-regime caveat. Post 3 addresses the cherry-picking objection: placing both players in the full distribution of all BRef-era players who meet the career-length threshold.

Estimands

	Metric	Data Tier	Status
E1	Games missed per 82 — career durability	Game logs	**Done — both cohorts**
E3	Shot selection: 3PA/FGA, FTA/FGA on B2B vs rest	Game logs	**Done — both cohorts**
E2	4Q FT% degradation vs Q1–Q3	Quarter box scores	**Done (PG) — Stockton +4.1 pp, only improver; PF pending**
E4	4Q AST/TOV ratio vs full-game	Quarter box scores	**Degenerate at quarter resolution (52% zero-TOV rows); dropped**
E5	4Q TS% vs Q1–Q3	Quarter box scores	**Degenerate (21% coverage per quarter); dropped**
E6	Full Q1→Q2→Q3→Q4 scoring profile	Quarter box scores	**Done — both cohorts**

E1 and E3 are primary. E6 (profile plot) generated from existing quarter splits; committed to both posts.

Inference Approach

E1's denominator corrects for lockout-shortened seasons: 1999→50 games, 2012→66, 2020→65, 2021→72.

n_treated = 1 makes bootstrap CIs invalid. For E1/E3: resample the treatment label across all N cohort players 5,000 times; report where the observed gap falls in the null distribution. For E2/E4/E5: mixed-effects model `metric ~ quarter * is_treated + rest_days + (1|player_id)` via `statsmodels.MixedLM`; permutation resam-

ples `is_treated` at the player level (not game level) to preserve within-player correlation.

Current Status

Infrastructure: complete. 141 tests passing across four scripts:

Script	Purpose
`fetch_bref_data.py`	BRef game log scraper; HTML-cached per (player, season); 4 sec/request
`analyze_durability.py`	E1 + E3; OLS + permutation; emits `{cohort}_comparators.csv`
`fetch_quarter_splits.py`	Quarter box score scraper; cached by game ID; 3.5s/request + jitter
`analyze_quarter_splits.py`	E2/E4/E5; mixed-effects model; player-level permutation

Data fetch: complete for PG and PF cohorts; population fetch running on Apollo via Docker + ProtonVPN.

Status	Players
Full PG game logs + quarter splits	Stockton, Payton, Jackson, Harper
Full PG game logs only	Thomas, Hardaway, K. Johnson, Porter, Bogues, Strickland, Kidd, Nash, Blaylock, Anderson, Douglas
PF game logs + quarter splits (all 6)	Diaw, Nowitzki, Boozer, Jamison, Marion, Lewis
Population (Apollo Docker fetch)	594/1,995 players fetched; production retry + VPN-rotation fixes applied 2026-10-13

Post drafts:

Post	E1/E3	E2/E4/E5	E6	Status
Stockton	Written	E2 written; E4/E5 dropped	Written	**Published** (draft removed; freeze committed)
Diaw	Written	E2 written (null); E4/E5 dropped	Written	**Published** (draft removed; freeze committed)
Population	—	—	—	Outline only — blocked on population fetch

Caveats (mandatory in every post)

1. **Selection-on-outcome bias** — >=600-game threshold conditions on the dependent variable; E1 estimates durability *among players who completed long careers*, not all players.
2. **B2B state selection** — playing a B2B selects healthier player-states; within-player pairing removes stable effects but not selection.
3. **Blowout/garbage time** — starters sit in non-competitive games; 4Q minutes are not random. Compresses treatment effect toward zero.
4. **Intentional fouling** — close-game FTA inflation in Q4; FT% estimates partly reflect pressure context, not just physical state.
5. **Timeout-adjusted rest** — unmeasured confounder; coaches use Q4 timeouts strategically.
6. **Age-regime** — Stockton's quarter data covers ages 34–40 (career decline). A null within-game result does not contradict a prime-years resilience claim.
7. **Pre-1996 quarter gap** — BRef play-by-play starts 1996-97; only Stockton ages 34–40 are covered. Justin Jacobs (Squared Statistics) has video-reconstructed pre-1996 quarter logs that would extend the window to his prime (ages 22–33). Outreach drafted, not sent.
8. **No causality** — frame consistently as "consistent with" and "does not contradict."

What's Left

Step	Blocker	Est.
Population fetch (Apollo Docker)	Running — 594/1,995 done; ~1,400 remaining	2–3 days
Population analysis + post	Population fetch complete	1 day
Jacobs outreach (#22) — manual browser form	Human action required	20 min
Blog infra: Makefile/CI/JS hardening (C1–C9)	Changes staged locally — awaiting commit	30 min

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NOTE: Causal language forbidden. Null results are valid findings — state them plainly. Sourcing asymmetry: Diaw's 35 BPM comes from documented post-retirement interviews; the Stockton figure is less sourced — acknowledge this explicitly in the Stockton post.

Changelog

v4 — 2026-10-13

- **Apollo fetch: Docker production hardening** — `fetch_bref_data.py` rewritten with:
  - Env-configurable rate limits: `SESSION_COOLDOWN_PAGES=40` (was 20), `SESSION_COOLDOWN_SEC=120` (was 300)
  - `_rotate_vpn()`: calls Gluetun HTTP control server (`PUT /v1/vpn/status` stop → start) on consecutive 403s; 15s reconnect wait
  - 5-retry loop in `_get_html()` catching `Timeout` + `ConnectionError` (15*2^n backoff per attempt); previously no try/except existed
  - 403 counter → automatic VPN rotation after `MAX_403_BEFORE_ROTATE=3` consecutive blocks
  - Per-player `try/except Exception` in `fetch_population_cohort` — bad player skipped, run continues
- **`docker-compose.yml` updated**: `restart: on-failure:10` for `bref-fetch`; env vars for all rate-limit/VPN params; `gluetun-auth.toml` volume-mounted for Gluetun control server auth (v3.40+ requires auth config)
- **`gluetun-auth.toml` created**: grants unauthenticated access to `PUT/GET /v1/vpn/status` (control-only; no admin)
- **Containers rebuilt and running**: Gluetun + bref-fetch healthy; resumed from 594/1,995 players
- **Observed SSL EOF errors**: BRef resets SSL connections on VPN IPs (harder block than 403); correctly caught by `ConnectionError` handler and retried
- **Blog infrastructure: panel synthesis C1–C9** — Makefile rewrite (freeze-safe `clean`, `clean-freeze CONFIRM=yes`, `bootstrap`, `lint`, `lint-fix`, `check`); CI adds lint + pytest steps; JS canvas hardening (reduced-motion bail-out, DPR scaling, visibility-change pause); archive exclusions in `_quarto.yml`; `pyproject.toml` glob fix (`**` for nested test dirs); `.gitignore` excludes `game_logs.parquet`; changes staged, not yet committed

v3.1 — 2026-10-12

- **Docker setup for Apollo fetch** — migrated population fetch from nohup to Docker Compose with Gluetun ProtonVPN for IP rotation; `Dockerfile` + `docker-compose.yml` + `requirements.txt` (pinned to working venv: beautifulsoup4, lxml, numpy, pandas, pyarrow, requests)
- **Fixed missing deps**: first build failed with `ImportError: Unable to find a usable engine` (missing pyarrow); second failed with `ImportError: Import lxml failed`; both added to `requirements.txt`
- **Fetch resumed at 594/1,995 players** (236,972 rows) after Docker migration
- **403 blocks from ProtonVPN IPs**: BRef actively blocks datacenter/VPN IPs with HTTP 403; `on-failure:10` not yet set (set in v4)

v3 — 2026-10-11

- **E6 plots added** — `plot_e6_quarter_profile()` added to `analyze_quarter_splits.py`; generates Q1→Q4 FT% line chart highlighting treated player. PG: Stockton is the only player with a monotonic Q1→Q4 rise

(76.9% → 80.6% → 83.2% → 84.7%). PF: Diaw shows slight Q4 decline (67.7%), Marion is the Q4 outlier (82.2%).

- **E6 figures generated** for both cohorts (`data/figures/pg/e6_quarter_profile.png`, `data/figures/pf/e6_quarter_pr` figures committed.
- **E6 section added to both posts** — Stockton post: updated from "pending" placeholder to real figure with caption; conclusion updated with monotonic-increase note. Diaw post: new E6 section inserted after E5.
- **Diaw E2/E4/E5 complete** — PF quarter splits were already fetched (Oct 10); analysis complete; post draft finished.
- **Posts 1 + 2 published** — `draft: true` removed from Stockton and Diaw posts; `jupyter: blog` added to frontmatter; `_freeze/` outputs generated locally and committed; CI will serve frozen outputs without re-executing Python.
- **CI fixed** — kernel registration (`python -m ipykernel install --user --name blog`) added to `publish.yml`; last green run 2026-10-09.
- **Population fetch running locally** — PID 39001; ~109 population players fetched so far; ETA ~Oct 14.
- 141 tests passing (was 131 after Oct 10 session).

v2 — 2026-10-10 (updated same day)

- BRef ID fixes: Bogues (`boguemu01`), Harper (`harpede01`), Strickland (`stricro02`) — PG cohort grew from 12 → 15 players
- E1 + E3 analysis complete for both PG (15 players) and PF (6 players)
- Stockton post drafted with E1/E3 results; E2/E4/E5 sections stubbed pending figures
- Diaw post drafted with E1/E3 results; E2/E4/E5 sections stubbed
- Quarter splits fetched for Payton, Jackson, Harper, Stockton (5,585 rows)
- E2/E4/E5 analysis run for PG cohort; E2 interpretable (Stockton Q4 FT% +4.1 pp, only improver, p=0.494 at floor); E4/E5 dropped — degenerate at per-quarter resolution (52% zero-TOV rows; 21% TS% coverage)
- Stockton post now complete draft (E1/E3/E2 written; E4/E5 explained as methodologically degenerate)
- Population fetch scope expanded to include centers; running on Apollo (232/1,995 players, 99,883 rows)
- Population cohort size: 1,995 players (guards + forwards + centers, debuts 1980–2010)
- Fixed 5 bugs in `fetch_quarter_splits.py`: Age column KeyError, rate limit (0.35s→3.5s+jitter), 429 backoff, game_id Tm→Team column, season range (1996→1997)
- Fixed parallel `--player` race condition in `fetch_bref_data.py` with `fcntl.flock()`

v1 — 2026-10-09

- Initial status document; infrastructure complete (131 tests); data fetch incomplete